

A DECKBUILDING POKER DUEL

KAIZEN POKER

Sculpt the perfect deck.



PLAYERS
2-4

TIME
25-35'

AGES
10+

1 Overview

Each round, players take turns playing Actions, then simultaneously make the best poker hand they can. The catch: every card you spend on its Action is a card you can't score.

The game is best with 2 players; add a second 52-card deck to play 3 or 4. A game runs about 25–35 minutes.

2 Components

52 cards · 13 chips. One deck supports a two-player game. For 3–4 players, combine two 52-card decks.

3 Setup

1 **DECKS.** Shuffle all cards and deal 26 to each player — these are your decks. Set any leftovers aside.

2 **FIRST PLAYER.** The player with the best poker face goes first.

4 Objective

Each round, the best poker hand wins one of the 13 chips. The first player to an insurmountable lead — 7 chips in a two-player game — wins.



5 How to Play

Each round has four phases:

- 1 **DRAW.** Each player draws seven cards.
- 2 **ACTION.** In clockwise turn order, each player plays two cards as Actions, resolving each as it is played.
- 3 **SCORE.** Five cards now remain in hand. All players reveal at once; the best five-card poker hand wins a chip.
- 4 **CLEANUP.** Move every played Action and revealed scoring card to its owner's discard pile.

NEW TO THE GAME?

Learn the rhythm with **Introductory Mode** (back page) before using the printed Action abilities.

ANATOMY OF A CARD



- 1 **RANK & SUIT.** Doubles as your scoring material when the card stays in hand.
- 2 **NAME.** The card's identity.
- 3 **TYPE.** When and how the Action resolves (see *Action Types*).
- 4 **ABILITY.** What the Action does.

6 Action Types

ENACT

Resolves immediately when played.

REACT

Stays in play and resolves later, when its trigger occurs.

MODIFY

When you reveal your scoring hand, assign one scoring card to this Action; it changes that card's rank or suit.

AMEND

Changes the rules of the game while it is in play.

REMEMBER

Does nothing as an Action — but changes the rules for both players while it sits in the scrap pile.

REFRESH

Instead of its printed Action, any card may be played **face down** as a Refresh: discard a card, then draw a card.

MODIFY, BY EXAMPLE

Play **Nudge** as an Action. At scoring, assign it to one of your five cards to shift that card's rank by one — turning a near-miss into a straight.

7 Table & Terms

LAYOUT

Keep your deck and discard to one side. Lay Actions side by side so both players can read them, and when you reveal your scoring hand, make clear which cards any Modify is altering.

VOCABULARY

- ♦ **SCRAP** — move a card from your *discard* (never your hand) to the scrap pile, shared by both players.
- ♦ **DRAW** — take the top card of your deck. If your deck is empty, shuffle your discard face down into a new deck and keep drawing.
- ♦ **TARGET** — specify. If there is no legal target, the Action cannot resolve.



ENACT



REACT



MODIFY



AMEND



REMEMBER

8 Hand Rankings

Five-card hands, lowest to highest. Beyond the classics, Kaizen Poker recognizes four special hands (in gold).

	HAND	WHAT IT IS
1	High Card	Highest single card; nothing else made.
2	Pair	Two cards of one rank.
3	Twins	Two cards of the same rank <i>and</i> suit.
4	Two Pair	Two different pairs.
5	Three of a Kind	Three cards of one rank.
6	Straight	Five in sequence, any suits.
7	Flush	Five of one suit, any ranks.
8	Full House	Three of a kind plus a pair.
9	Four of a Kind	Four cards of one rank.
10	Straight Flush	Five in sequence, one suit.
11	Royal Flush	A 10–A straight flush.
12	Five of a Kind	Five cards of one rank.
13	Flush House	A full house, all one suit.
14	Flush Five	Five identical cards — same rank and suit.

TIES

Identical hands split nothing — no chip is awarded that round.



9 Ending the Game

The first player to 7 of the 13 chips wins. Two rules sharpen the endgame:

SUDDEN DEATH

At the start of any round in which a player could win, every *other* player draws eight cards and plays three Actions — still scoring five.

RUNNING DRY

If a player cannot draw a full hand at the start of a round — even after reshuffling — they lose the game.

10 The Deck at a Glance

- ♦ **2s** — Enact; scrap a discard card of the listed suits.
- ♦ **3s** — quick card selection.
- ♦ **4s** — search out specific cards; discard as directed.
- ♦ **5s & Aces** — return an Action from play to your hand.
- ♦ **6s & 7s** — disrupt opponents, or steal from them.
- ♦ **8s & 9s** — scrap cards of various kinds.
- ♦ **10s** — alter one scoring card's rank or suit.
- ♦ **Js** — some modify a scoring card; others enter as copies of an Action.
- ♦ **Qs** — inert as Actions, but rewrite the rules for both players while scrapped.
- ♦ **Ks** — big, splashy effects.
- ♦ **As** — “go up a rank,” and grant an extra Action.



11 Solo Variant

Deal two piles of 26: one is your deck, the other the **Challenger's**. Play rounds as normal — draw seven, play two, score five. When you reveal your hand, flip the top card of the Challenger's deck; its rank names the hand the Challenger made:

CARD	CHALLENGER'S HAND
2	High Card
3	Pair
4	Twins
5	Two Pair
6	Three of a Kind
7	Straight
8	Flush
9	Full House
10	Four of a Kind
J	Straight Flush
Q	Royal Flush
K	Five of a Kind
A	Flush House / Flush Five

SCORING

Beat the Challenger to take the chip; ties go to the Challenger. Play until the chips run out (about 13 rounds). Your final margin is your score — 7 **or better is a win**. Cards that target an opponent do little here; consider cutting them from your deck.



To learn the rhythm, play once **ignoring every printed Action ability**. You still draw seven, play two cards as Actions, and score the remaining five — but each Action is played *face down*, and for each you choose one:

- ♦ Draw a card, then discard a card; *or*
- ♦ Scrap a card.

Once the flow feels natural, start over and play with the abilities printed on the cards.

A NOTE ON THE ART

The illustrations in this prototype were generated with Google's ImageFX, used in place of generic clip art to convey a specific direction for each card. The published edition is not intended to use generative art.

